Employee handbook

01 Company and handbook scope

Cedar Labs is a fictional software company with 42 employees working on internal business applications. Its teams are Engineering, Product, Customer Operations and People Operations. The main office is in the fictional city of Lakebridge. This handbook is a synthetic reading exercise, not a real employment policy or legal document.

The handbook describes everyday working arrangements for full-time employees in this fictional organization. Contractors follow their individual agreements. Questions about an unclear section go to People Operations; managers should not invent exceptions. The current handbook is version 1.2, effective 1 July 2026. Employees receive a copy during onboarding and can request an accessible text version.

Organization	Cedar Labs
Employees	42
Version	1.2
Effective date	1 July 2026

Reading note: answer from this document only. If a requested detail is absent, say that it is not specified.

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02 Onboarding and equipment

A new employee completes onboarding during the first five working days. People Operations verifies the joining checklist, Engineering provisions a company laptop, and the manager assigns an onboarding buddy. The buddy answers practical questions and introduces the new employee to the team. Production access is not automatically granted during onboarding.

The standard equipment kit contains one laptop, one headset and one external monitor. Employees acknowledge receipt in the equipment register. A manager reviews access requests after the employee finishes the security orientation. During the first week, the employee attends a product walkthrough, reads the team runbook and completes a small supervised task. The manager holds a check-in at the end of day five.

Onboarding period	First five working days
Equipment	Laptop, headset and external monitor
First manager check-in	End of day five
Production access	Separate manager review required

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03 Remote work and office attendance

Cedar Labs allows full-time employees to work remotely for up to three days per week. Tuesday and Thursday are the standard office days for team collaboration. Monday, Wednesday and Friday may be remote days when the employee has reliable internet and an appropriate workspace. Remote work does not change agreed working hours or delivery responsibilities.

An employee requests a temporary change to an office day through the team manager at least one working day beforehand. A manager may approve a one-week exception for a specific situation and records it in the attendance calendar. The exception does not create a permanent remote arrangement. Employees update the shared calendar before starting a remote day so teammates can plan meetings.

Remote allowance	Up to three days per week
Office days	Tuesday and Thursday
Exception notice	At least one working day
Attendance record	Shared team calendar

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04 Working hours and meetings

The standard workday has eight working hours, excluding a lunch break. Teams share a core collaboration window from 10:00 to 16:00 local office time. Start and finish times may vary around that window when agreed with the manager. Employees record planned absences rather than sending repeated status updates throughout the day.

The engineering stand-up begins at 10:15 and lasts no longer than fifteen minutes. Longer technical discussions move to a separate session. Wednesday afternoons are reserved for focused work unless a customer incident requires coordination. Meeting owners send an agenda in advance and write down decisions afterward. People who cannot attend can review the notes and add questions asynchronously.

Daily working time	Eight hours, excluding lunch
Core window	10:00 to 16:00
Stand-up	10:15, maximum fifteen minutes
Focus time	Wednesday afternoons

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05 Leave requests

Full-time employees receive eighteen days of annual leave in this fictional policy. They submit planned annual leave through the leave register at least five working days before the first day away. The manager checks delivery coverage and replies within two working days. Approval is recorded in the register rather than inferred from a calendar invitation.

Unexpected illness is reported to the manager as soon as practical; the five-day planning rule does not apply to illness. Employees do not share medical details in the team channel. Before planned leave, employees identify a backup owner for active work and add a short handover note. Unused annual leave treatment is outside this sample and must not be inferred from the eighteen-day allowance.

Annual leave	Eighteen days
Planned notice	Five working days
Manager response	Within two working days
Handover	Backup owner and short note

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06 Learning and development

Each employee has a learning budget of 12,000 credits per calendar year. Credits are fictional internal accounting units, not a real currency. The budget may cover technical books, approved online courses or a conference ticket. A manager approves the learning request before the employee makes a purchase.

Employees may reserve two working hours each week for approved learning. They agree on a useful outcome with the manager, such as a small prototype, written notes or a team demonstration. The company encourages learning related to current responsibilities and future team needs. Unused learning credits expire at the end of the calendar year and cannot be exchanged for cash. A course completion alone does not guarantee promotion.

Annual budget	12,000 fictional credits
Learning time	Two working hours per week
Approval	Before purchase
Unused credits	Expire at calendar-year end

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07 Expenses and reimbursements

Employees submit approved business expenses within thirty calendar days of the purchase. Each request includes a receipt, a business purpose and the name of the approving manager. People Operations checks the request for completeness before sending it to Finance. Missing receipts are returned for clarification rather than automatically reimbursed.

Finance processes complete reimbursement requests in the next monthly expense cycle. The submission deadline for that cycle is the twentieth day of the month. Requests received after the deadline move to the following cycle. Personal subscriptions, commuting costs and unapproved equipment are excluded from this sample policy. An employee should request approval before spending money rather than assuming that submitting a receipt guarantees repayment.

Submission window	Thirty calendar days from purchase
Monthly cutoff	Twentieth day of the month
Required evidence	Receipt, purpose and manager approval
Processing	Next eligible monthly expense cycle

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08 Security and data handling

Employees use multi-factor authentication for company accounts and keep work on managed devices. They lock their screens when leaving a desk. Customer data must not be copied into personal cloud drives or public AI tools. A tool requires approval before it receives confidential information, even if the tool offers a free account.

A suspected account compromise or lost company device is reported to the security contact immediately. Employees preserve relevant details and do not attempt to hide an accidental disclosure. The security team coordinates containment and records the incident. The handbook does not authorize employees to test systems they do not own. Access follows the minimum permissions needed for an assigned task and is reviewed when responsibilities change.

Account protection	Multi-factor authentication
Device policy	Managed work devices
Incident notice	Immediately
Access principle	Minimum permissions for the task

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09 Feedback and performance

Managers hold a thirty-minute one-to-one meeting with each employee every two weeks. The conversation covers current work, obstacles, feedback and development. Either participant can add agenda items. The meeting is a regular support mechanism rather than a surprise performance assessment.

Formal performance reviews happen twice each year, in June and December. Review notes describe observable work and agreed goals. The employee can add written context before the review is finalized. Promotion decisions consider role expectations and available responsibilities; they are not determined by course certificates or hours online. Employees can raise unresolved concerns with People Operations when direct discussion with the manager does not resolve them.

One-to-one cadence	Every two weeks
Meeting length	Thirty minutes
Formal reviews	June and December
Escalation	People Operations

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10 Leaving and returning equipment

When an employee leaves Cedar Labs, People Operations opens an exit checklist and confirms the last working day with the manager. The employee documents active tasks and identifies where working files are stored. Ownership of shared documents moves to a designated teammate before access is removed.

Company equipment is returned within five working days of the last working day. The equipment team checks the register and issues a return receipt. Access to company accounts is disabled on the last working day according to the exit checklist. Personal copies of company information are not retained. This fictional handbook does not specify notice periods, severance or final-pay rules, so those topics cannot be answered from this document.

Equipment return	Within five working days
Account removal	Last working day
Handover record	Active tasks, files and new owners
Not specified	Notice period, severance and final pay

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